THE ZAHEERA BOOMGAARD STORY

A SOUTH AFRICAN TRUE CRIME DOCUMENTARY SERIES

FORMAT: 4 X 60 MINUTES

INFINITYFILMS

LOGLINE

When veteran journalist Susan Purén walks into a nearly empty courtroom during Covid lockdown to report on what seems like a routine fraud case, she stumbles into a true crime saga that shocks even seasoned detectives. The woman in the dock—Zaheera Boomgaard—is accused of manipulation, murder, and decades of deception. But as the forensic evidence, forged wills, and dark family secrets begin to unravel, it becomes clear: this is not just one of South Africa's most disturbing criminal cases. It's a generational descent into evil that played out in plain sight.

“LET ME TELL YOU A STORY”

A charred, unidentifiable body in a field.
Another, nearby, reduced to little more than a pair of shoes.
A plastic bag soaked in blood. A till slip from a local grocery store.

Separate police units begin piecing together different cases. They are about to discover they're chasing the same woman.
Her name: Zaheera Boomgaard.

She was neat, polite, and deeply religious. She sold curry and samoosas from her apartment during lockdown. Her neighbours trusted her. Her friends adored her.

But behind the smile was a woman who allegedly impersonated the dead, stole from their bank accounts, and rewrote their wills to favour herself.

She used victims' phones long after they were gone. She called banks, pretending to be them. She posted as them on Facebook. And in a chilling statement to police, she said simply:
“Let me tell you a story.”
Zaheera never confessed to murder. But she did admit to burying her own newborn baby alive as a teenager.

This is not just a case file. It's one of the most haunting unsolved mysteries of post-apartheid South Africa. A story of faith and fraud, of charm and betrayal. A slow-burning horror that nearly vanished into silence—until a pandemic slowed everything down enough for someone to notice.

SERIES SUMMARY

The Zaheera Boomgaard Story is a four-part South African true crime documentary told with the tension of a psychological thriller and the emotional truth of lived experience. It follows journalist Susan Purén, who thought she was covering a minor fraud case—until she found herself chronicling one of the most disturbing and overlooked serial crime stories in South African history.

At the centre is Zaheera Boomgaard: a soft-spoken, religious woman who served curry to neighbours during lockdown, quoted scripture in public, and allegedly orchestrated the deaths and disappearances of multiple men and women across decades. She didn't leave behind bodies in back alleys—she left altered wills, empty estates, and Facebook profiles still posting long after the victims were dead.

The investigation that finally caught her only happened because of a national lockdown. A team of underutilised forensic experts noticed overlaps in separate cases. The same name kept surfacing. And as the evidence mounted—bloodied towels, forged documents, a burned body, and a till slip—so too did the scale of the horror.
Zaheera's story is also the story of a family soaked in generational violence. A brother hanged for murder. Another shot before his own trial. A nephew once accused of matricide. She didn't emerge from nowhere—she emerged from within.

This series brings it all to light: a forensic team that refused to quit, a journalist who bore witness, and a killer who may have gotten away with far more than she was charged for. Through exclusive access to police files, audio recordings, metadata, and Susan's own private archives, The Zaheera Boomgaard Story reconstructs how one woman nearly slipped through the cracks—and why her story demands to be told now.

WHY IT BELONGS ON NETFLIX AFRICA

This is a homegrown story with global appeal: uniquely South African in tone and location, yet universally compelling in structure. It offers:

- A female killer unlike anything seen before in true crime—a quiet predator who moved between religions, communities, and lovers.
- A gripping mix of forensic investigation, psychological mystery, and social commentary.
- Powerful South African law enforcement figures who, for once, come off as heroes.
- A journalist's deeply personal journey into a story that rattled even seasoned court reporters.

And most importantly, The Zaheera Boomgaard Story speaks to Netflix Africa's desire to platform real stories, strong female voices, and content with local flavour and international standard.

KEY CHARACTERS

01

02

03

04

ZAHEERA BOOMGAARD – THE ACCUSED

Elegant, devout, maternal—until she wasn't. Zaheera Boomgaard is accused of weaving herself into the lives of vulnerable, often lonely people, and slowly removing them from existence. She allegedly stole identities, forged signatures, and used her knowledge of religion and community to build trust before manipulating the legal system to take over their estates.

She is suspected of forging the will of her bedridden friend Marlene Mustapha, redirecting an inheritance worth over R7 million into her own name. With Marlene gone, Zaheera allegedly turned to her sister Lynette—the next in line—and within weeks, Lynette was found burned to death in a field near Zaheera's home.

Zaheera denies all the charges. But in her warning statement to police, she did admit to something else: burying her newborn baby alive at 16.

She wasn't hiding in the shadows. She was hiding in plain sight—in WhatsApp groups, on dating apps, and in the pulpit at her daughter's church.

SUSAN PURÉN – THE WITNESS

Susan Purén is an investigative journalist & television producer based in South Africa.

She has won numerous awards including the prestiges CNN African Journalist of the Year in 2002 for her television documentary, China War Child, about the life of a former child soldier, China Keitetsi.

A seasoned journalist who thought she was covering a routine fraud case—and ended up embedded in one of South Africa's most disturbing criminal sagas. Susan is not a detective; she is the voice of reason and restraint in a story that grows darker with every turn. Her private interviews, courtroom notes, and emotional reflections give the series its spine and soul.

THE VICTIMS

01

Hari Nathvani – A retired Tube manager from London. Travelled to South Africa after meeting Zaheera on an Indian dating site. His body was burned and dumped in Walkerville. His bank cards were used after his death. His phone was still connecting to her WiFi.

02

Lynette Mustapha – A trusting neighbour and churchgoer. Found burned in the veldt. Her will was allegedly altered to leave everything to Zaheera. Her sister had died weeks earlier.

03

Marlene Mustapha – Lynette's older, bedridden sister. Morbidly obese and unable to leave the house. Her will was forged. It transferred R7 million in assets to Zaheera—bypassing her next-of-kin. Marlene's death was ruled natural. But with both sisters dead, Zaheera stood to inherit it all.

04

John Naisby – A retired British engineer living in Cape Town. Disappeared after visiting Zaheera in Gauteng. She used his phone and bank cards. His body was never found.

THE INVESTIGATORS

01

Brigadier Leoni Ras, Colonel Hoosen Samaad & W/O Kevin Govender – The forensic team who finally had time during lockdown to follow the trail. Their combined instincts uncovered Zaheera's pattern.

02

Captain Werner van den Bergh – The lead investigator who connected victims to forged wills, ATM withdrawals, cellphone metadata, and tollgate movements.

03

Colonel Vinol Viljoen – Took Zaheera's original statement, including her chilling admission about her infant child.

04

Pieter White – Former SAPS, FBI-trained. His 206-page metadata report created the timeline that brought everything together.

THE BASDEO FAMILY — A BLOODLINE OF VIOLENCE

01

Prem Basdeo – Zaheera's brother. A former police officer accused of killing two wives. Shot dead the night before his trial.

02

Jordan Basdeo – Prem's son. Accused of shooting his mother in her sleep. Acquitted.

03

Amichand Basdeo – Another brother., was convicted and executed in the 1980s for the murder of a fellow police officer.

04

Robert Basdeo – Linked to criminal activity. Believed to have helped Zaheera cover her tracks.

EPISODIC BREAKDOWN

EPISODE 1: "THE BODIES"
The story begins in the quiet strangeness of lockdown South Africa. Two separate police teams—each investigating unrelated cases—come across two burned bodies in the veld near Walkerville. One is eventually identified as British retiree Hari Nathvani. The other is Lynette Mustapha. A single clue connects the scenes: a plastic bag filled with bloodied towels and a till slip from a local store.
Journalist Susan Purén enters a half-empty courtroom expecting a minor fraud case—and finds Zaheera Boomgaard. As the links between cases emerge, the episode sets up the mystery: who is this woman, and how is she connected to so many deaths?

EPISODE 2: "THE DOUBLE LIFE"
This episode uncovers Zaheera's carefully constructed web of deceit. She presents herself as a widow, a medical professional, a Christian healer. But behind the mask is a woman who allegedly preys on the lonely and isolated.
We examine her financial manipulation: the R7 million inheritance stolen through the forged will of Marlene Mustapha. How Marlene died bedridden. How her sister Lynette—next in line—died weeks later. We explore how victims' phones continued to post to Facebook and connect to WiFi after their deaths. We meet Sakeena, Zaheera's daughter, and begin to question just how deep this manipulation runs.

EPISODIC BREAKDOWN

EPISODE 3: "THE FAMILY TREE"

Violence is in Zaheera's bloodline. This episode is a forensic breakdown of the Basdeo family: Zaheera's brother Amichand, hanged for killing a fellow officer. Prem, who faced two murder charges before being gunned down. Jordan, once accused of matricide. Robert, allegedly involved in body disposal.

As the psychological profile of Zaheera sharpens, Susan interviews investigators who followed her for years. Their testimonies reveal the blind spots in our institutions that allowed someone like this to operate for so long.

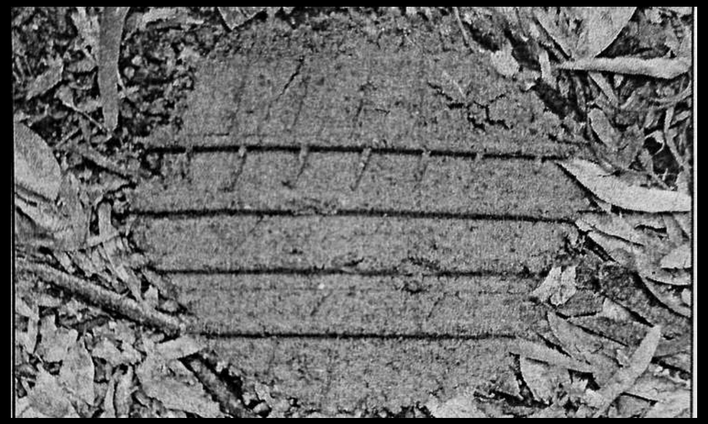
EPISODE 4: "THE RECKONING"

The final episode moves into the courtroom. Zaheera is now frail, quoting scripture, denying everything. But the case against her is overwhelming: banking logs, forged wills, tollbooth cameras, digital traces, and one final damning phone call to a UK bank in the voice of a dead man.

We also follow Susan as she speaks to surviving relatives. What does justice look like when many victims were cremated or erased? How many others may never be accounted for?

The series closes with a chilling question: was Zaheera the only one—or simply the only one caught?

TONE



VISUAL STYLE & STORYTELLING DEVICES

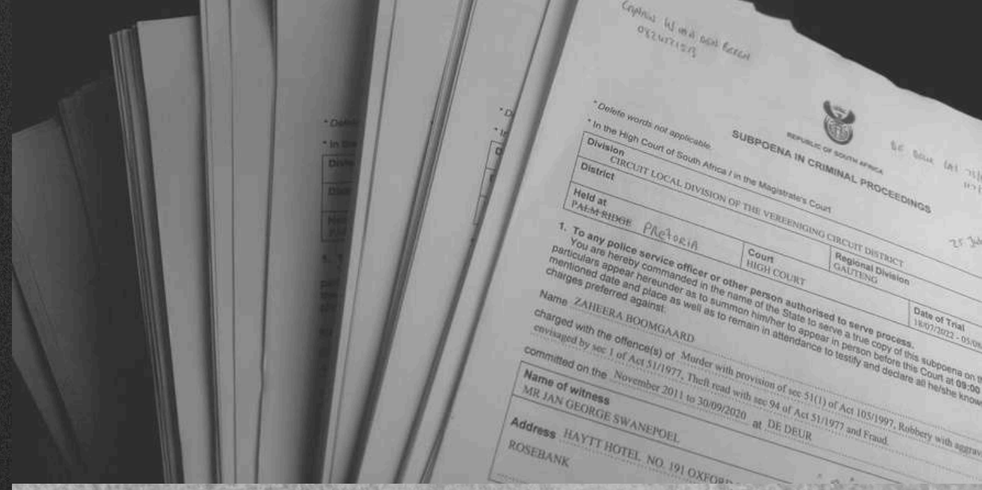
This is not a static courtroom documentary. The Zaheera Boomgaard Story will be realised with the intensity, pacing, and cinematic depth of a high-end psychological thriller. Every beat—every revelation—pulls us deeper into the maze that Susan herself was drawn into. It's investigative journalism with the aesthetic of noir, the detail of a forensic file, and the intimacy of a personal reckoning.

CINEMATIC RECREATION & ATMOSPHERIC DETAIL

- Reenactments will not dramatise murder scenes graphically, but will bring to life the quiet dread of ordinary moments: a friendly meal shared over lockdown; a calm church service where Zaheera scopes her next victim; an innocuous signature on a will that seals someone's fate.
- Photorealistic textures—court transcripts, forged documents, Facebook posts written by the dead, banking logs, WhatsApp voice notes—will be woven into the story using stylised overlays and forensic animations.
- Locations—veld fields, modest flats, police archives—are filmed like characters: full of shadow, memory, and unnerving silence.

The series is scored with quiet tension: breath, clocks ticking, wind over empty farmland. There are no jump scares—only dread that builds and never quite releases.

COMPANION MATERIALS & ACCESS



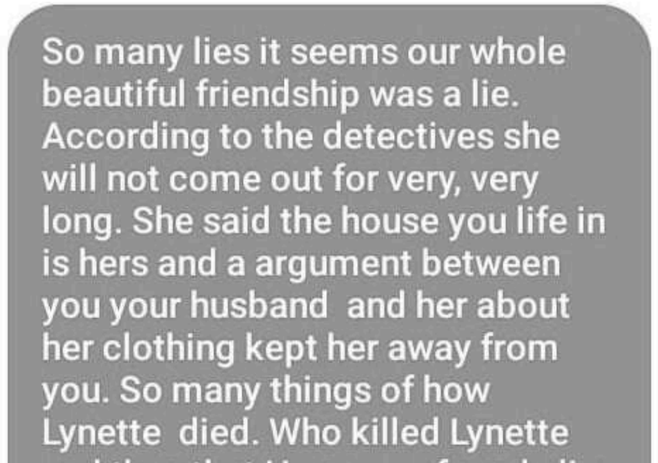
We have exceptional access to primary evidence, exclusive content, and personal recordings that ensure this series is both credible and impossible to replicate.

POLICE & CASE FILES

- All official SAPS statements from detectives involved in the cases of Hari Nathvani, Lynette Mustapha, and John Naisby.
- Crime scene photographs (photocopies and possible full access) for both confirmed victims.
- Full documentation of the Naisby case, including statements from Mrs. Naisby and her daughter Alida.
- All relevant investigative records from Captain Werner van den Bergh, including case summaries and forensic findings.
- Photos of Zaheera's arrests from 2020 (first and second).

AUDIO RECORDINGS

- Official courtroom audio of Boomgaard's evidence and cross-examination (not synced with visuals).
- Audio recording of Boomgaard's FNB call, falsely claiming to be the executrix of the Mustapha sisters' wills.
- Phone call to Santander Bank in the UK, with Boomgaard impersonating Nathvani.
- Sakeena Nicholson recording, stating: "I think my mom killed my dad."
- Lt Col Flip Claasen interview audio, detailing early investigation.
- Col Vinol Viljoen interview, including the moment Boomgaard said: "Let me tell you a story..."
- Audio from Boomgaard's seized phones, recovered and forensically downloaded by expert Chris Delport.



DIGITAL FORENSICS & TRACKER DATA

- Pieter White's 206-page tracker analysis spreadsheets, placing Zaheera's vehicle at multiple crime-related sites.
- Cellphone metadata from victims' and Zaheera's devices, mapped to WiFi access, location logs, and data pings.
- WhatsApp conversations, Facebook activity from deceased accounts, toll data, ATM surveillance logs.

VIDEO & VISUAL EVIDENCE

- iPhone footage of Boomgaard testifying in court (no sound).
- Surveillance footage from OR Tambo International of Zaheera walking with Naisby.

KEY WITNESS ACCESS

- Statements and private audio interviews with Sakeena Nicholson, Zaheera's daughter.
- Interviews with the Mustapha siblings, Mrs. Naisby and her daughter, and close neighbours.
- Court transcripts and legal documentation from the forged wills and estate disputes.

This depth of archival access ensures the production is rooted in irrefutable evidence—and provides an immersive lens into a crime that unfolded across years, victims, and digital trails.

SUSAN'S NARRATIVE POV

Susan Purén's voice is not a framing device—it is a mirror. Her narration is raw, personal, and often uneasy.

She speaks not just as a journalist, but as a witness: someone who sat in court, looked Zaheera in the eye, and still struggles to explain what she saw.

We hear real audio from her interviews. Her tape recorder hums as a police officer recalls the day they found the body. Her voice catches when she speaks to Lynette Mustapha's sister.

Her role in the series is not to solve the crime—but to reveal what it cost to tell the story truthfully.

DEPARTMENT HOME AFFAIRS
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

IDENTITY/IDENTITEIT

PARTICULARS FROM THE POPULATION REGISTER I.R.O.:

IDNO.:
IDNR.:

THANK YOU!

SURNAME:
VAN: RAJKUMAR

FIRST NAME:
VOORNAME: ZAHEERA

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